

8

Motivation: From Concepts to Applications



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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

After studying this chapter, you should be able to:

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| 8-1 Describe how the job characteristics model (JCM) motivates through job design. | 8-5 Demonstrate how different types of extrinsic pay programs can influence employee motivation. |
| 8-2 Compare the main ways jobs can be redesigned. | 8-6 Show how flexible benefits can motivate employees. |
| 8-3 Explain how specific alternative work arrangements can motivate employees. | 8-7 Identify the motivational benefits of intrinsic rewards. |
| 8-4 Describe how employee involvement measures can motivate employees. | |

Employability Skills Matrix (ESM)

	Myth or Science?	An Ethical Choice	Point/Counterpoint	Toward a Better World	Experiential Exercise	Ethical Dilemma	Case Incident
Critical Thinking & Creativity	✓		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Communication			✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Collaboration			✓		✓	✓	✓
Self-Management	✓		✓	✓			
Social Responsibility		✓		✓		✓	
Leadership	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Career Management	✓		✓				

TEACHER MERIT PAY: IS IT THE SOLUTION?

One of the most contentious topics related to education reform is that of teacher pay. There have been many teacher walkouts and strikes with teacher compensation as a central issue. For example, Chicago Public Schools, the nation's third-largest school district, eventually approved a historic 16 percent pay increase in 2019 after months of failed negotiations with the Chicago Teachers Union and eleven days of canceled classes. The American public also agrees that teachers should be paid more, with 60 percent of Americans believing school districts do not compensate teachers fairly.

In most school districts, teachers are usually paid based on the number of years they have been teaching and their education level. However, this system has been criticized as unfair because top-performing, long-tenured, and well-educated mediocre teachers are all paid the same salary. Alternatives to this system involve differentiating pay through performance-based incentives. These have all been met with considerable opposition, particularly from teacher union leaders. They argue that there is no objective definition of a “good teacher” and that these systems are biased as a result. Furthermore, critics of merit pay believe it is unfair to pay teachers based on criteria such as student achievement, arguing that there are many factors outside the classroom that can impact student learning, such as students' health and home environment.

Despite opposition, teacher merit pay programs are becoming more popular and have obtained financial and political support. The federal

government has allocated more than \$2 billion in more than thirty states to design and implement performance pay systems. The implementation of these programs, though, has not been without obstacles. In 2019, Denver teachers nearly went on strike against what was viewed by many as a promising merit pay system, ProComp. Although student achievement increased under this system, many teachers were dissatisfied with unpredictable fluctuations in their pay. In theory, merit pay may have the potential to improve teacher motivation and student achievement; however, implementing a pay-for-performance system may be ineffective at achieving the desired results.

There is also considerable debate among education researchers about merit pay's effect on teacher motivation. There is research demonstrating that teachers are more likely to remain in their jobs when their salary increases. However, an increase in base pay is the largest for less experienced teachers and tends to decrease with experience. Some also argue that merit pay systems can create competition among teachers, disincentivizing cooperation and collaboration among them. However, it depends on how the school district decides to implement the system. Suppose it is a zero-sum system where only the top ten teachers receive a financial incentive. In that case, it is more likely to create division than if all teachers could potentially qualify to earn up to a maximum bonus. Another version of a merit pay system may tie a proportion of one's performance evaluation to effective group participation. The idea is that this would create a greater incentive for teachers to share and discuss lessons and strategies, ultimately increasing the effectiveness of more teachers. The research also demonstrates a modest but statistically significant positive effect of merit pay programs on student test scores. Although merit pay may have a small effect on teacher motivation, intrinsic motivators may have a more substantial motivational effect than financial incentives.

In general, it appears that the key to effective merit pay is in how the programs are implemented. Rewarding teams of teachers results in a larger effect than awarding raises based on their rank-order in performance. It also can improve teacher recruitment and retention, which are particular challenges for schools in low-income communities. Thus, merit pay programs show promise, but administrators must pay careful attention to how these programs are implemented. Regardless, merit pay represents a significant shift in how numerous schools and organizations as a whole have operated for many years.¹

Organizations take a number of approaches toward encouraging, maintaining, and harnessing manager and employee motivation. Some focus on the nature of the job itself and involve designing work to emphasize the characteristics that are most motivating to workers or empowering workers to have a say in the work that they complete. On the other hand, some focus on the motivators

for work, including rewards and benefits. In this chapter, we discuss the many ways organizations approach motivation in the workplace.

In the previous chapter, we discussed the theory behind motivation. Here, we discuss application. Although not all theories brought up in the prior chapter are discussed here, you will come to find that major contemporary theories [e.g., self-determination theory (SDT)] play a large role. Of course, it is important to understand these underlying theories; it is also important to see how they can be applied in the workplace, beginning with job design.

Motivating by Job Design: The Job Characteristics Model (JCM)

The way work is structured has a bigger impact on an individual's motivation than it seems. For example, one survey of nearly three thousand working parents in the UK found that 78 percent were working beyond their contracted hours (despite having children to care for), mainly for workload reasons or because it was part of the culture to work overtime. Commenting on the results, one manager noted that employers should “really rethink job design to tackle the problem of overworking. Parents need more human-sized jobs.”²

Job design suggests that the way elements in a job are organized can influence employee effort,³ and the job characteristics model discussed next can serve as a framework to identify opportunities for changes to those elements. Considering our discussions from the prior chapter, many of the concepts to be discussed may seem familiar to you, including autonomy (a major component of SDT) and feedback (a key player in the goal-setting process). The **job characteristics model (JCM)** describes jobs in terms of five core job dimensions:⁴

1. **Skill variety** is the degree to which a job requires a variety of activities using different skills or talents. The work of a garage owner-operator who does electrical repairs, rebuilds engines, does bodywork, and interacts with customers scores high on skill variety. The job of a body shop worker who sprays paint eight hours a day scores low on this dimension.
2. **Task identity** is the degree to which a job requires completion of a whole and identifiable piece of work. A cabinetmaker who designs furniture, selects the wood, builds the furniture, and finishes the pieces has a job that scores high on task identity. A job scoring low on this dimension would involve operating a lathe solely to make table legs.
3. **Task significance** is the degree to which a job affects the lives or work of other people. The job of a nurse helping patients in a hospital intensive care unit scores high on task significance; sweeping floors in a hospital scores low.
4. **Autonomy** is the degree to which a job provides the worker freedom, independence, and discretion in scheduling work and determining the procedures for carrying it out. Sales managers who schedule their own work and tailor their sales approach to each customer without supervision have highly autonomous jobs. An account representative who is required to follow a standardized sales script with potential customers has a job low on autonomy.
5. **Feedback** is the degree to which carrying out work activities generates direct and clear information about your own performance. A job with high feedback would be testing and inspecting iPads. Installing components of iPads as they move down an assembly line provides low feedback.

8-1 Describe how the job characteristics model (JCM) motivates through job design.

job design The way the elements in a job are organized.

job characteristics model (JCM) A model proposing that any job can be described in terms of five core job dimensions: skill variety, task identity, task significance, autonomy, and feedback.

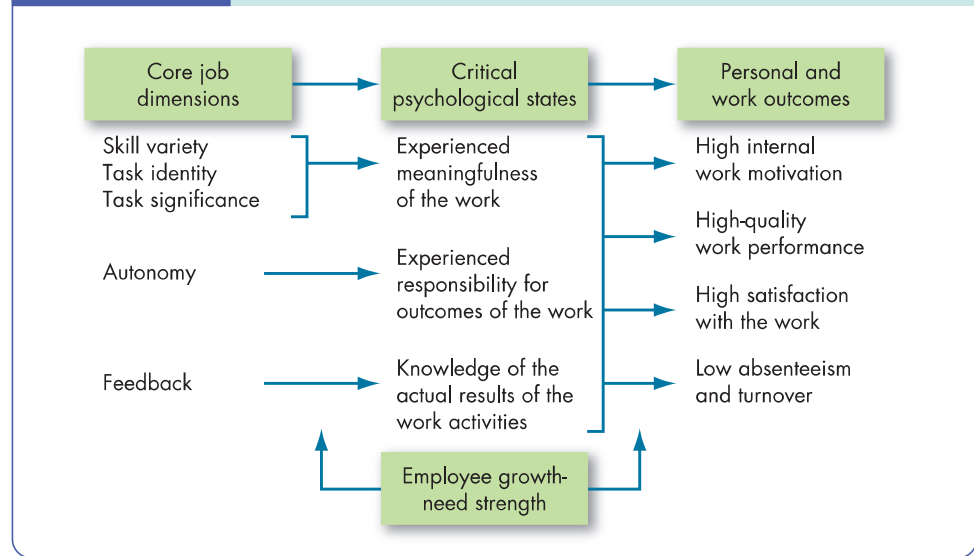
skill variety The degree to which a job requires a variety of activities using different skills or talents.

task identity The degree to which a job requires completion of a whole and identifiable piece of work.

task significance The degree to which a job has a substantial impact on the lives or work of other people.

autonomy The degree to which a job provides substantial freedom and discretion to the individual in scheduling the work and in determining the procedures to be used in carrying it out.

feedback The degree to which carrying out the work activities required by a job results in the individual obtaining direct and clear information about the effectiveness of the individual's performance.

Exhibit 8-1 The Job Characteristics Model

Source: Based on J. R. Hackman and G. R. Oldham, "Development of Job Diagnostic Survey," *Journal of Applied Psychology* 60, no. 2 (1975): 159–70; J. L. Pierce, I. Jussila, and A. Cummings, "Psychological Ownership Within the Job Design Context: Revision of the Job Characteristics Model," *Journal of Organizational Behavior* 30, no. 4 (2009): 477–96.

Elements of the JCM

Exhibit 8-1 presents the JCM. Note how the first three dimensions—skill variety, task identity, and task significance—combine to create meaningful work the employee will view as worthwhile. Jobs with high autonomy give employees a feeling of responsibility for work outcomes, and feedback shows them how effectively they are performing. The more these three psychological states (e.g., meaningfulness, responsibility, and knowledge of results) are present, the greater will be employees' motivation, performance, and satisfaction, and the lower their absenteeism and likelihood of leaving. As Exhibit 8-1 indicates, individuals with a high growth need are more likely to experience the critical psychological states when their jobs include these elements—and are more likely to respond to them more positively.

Efficacy of the JCM

Much evidence supports the relationship between the presence of these job characteristics and higher job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and experienced meaningfulness through increased motivation.⁵ Furthermore, although employees have noticed that jobs are becoming more autonomous and interdependent and requiring more skills than before, the relationships with job satisfaction have not changed since the 1970s, suggesting that employees still value enriched work.⁶ In general, research supports the JCM, although some personality and context differences exist. For example, studies suggest that the link between job characteristics and satisfaction are highest when employees tend to regularly experience positive moods (i.e., trait positive affect; see the chapter on emotions and moods).⁷ Other research has explored the JCM in unique settings such as in virtual work situations, finding that if individuals work together online but not in person, their experience of meaningfulness, responsibility, and knowledge of results can suffer.⁸ Thankfully, managers can mitigate these negative effects for employees by consciously developing personal relationships with them and increasing their sense of task significance, autonomy, and feedback.⁹

Motivating Potential Score (MPS)

We can combine the core dimensions of the JCM into a single predictive index, called the **motivating potential score (MPS)** and calculated as follows:

$$\text{MPS} = \frac{\text{skill variety} + \text{task identity} + \text{task significance}}{3} \times \text{autonomy} \times \text{feedback}$$

To be high on motivating potential, jobs must be high on at least one of the three factors that lead to experienced meaningfulness and high on both autonomy and feedback. If jobs score high on motivating potential, the model predicts that motivation, performance, and satisfaction will improve and that absences and turnover will be reduced. Think about your job (or one you have had in the past). Could you work on different tasks, or was there more of a routine? Could you work independently, or did you constantly have a supervisor or coworker looking over your shoulder? Your answers might indicate this job's motivating potential.

motivating potential score (MPS)

A predictive index that reflects the motivating potential in a job.

Job Redesign

“Every day was the same thing,” Cameron said. “Stand on that assembly line. Wait for an instrument panel to be moved into place. Unlock the mechanism and drop the panel into the Jeep Wrangler as it moved by on the line. Then I plugged in the harnessing wires. I repeated that for eight hours a day. I don’t care that they were paying me \$24 an hour. It was really taking a toll on me. Finally, I just said this isn’t going to be the way I’m going to spend the rest of my life. My brain was turning to JELL-O. So I quit. Now I work in a print shop and I make less than \$15 an hour. But let me tell you, the work I do is really interesting. The job changes all the time, I’m continually learning new things, and the work really challenges me! I look forward every morning to going to work again.”

The repetitive tasks in Cameron’s job at the Jeep plant provided little variety, autonomy, or motivation. In contrast, Cameron’s job in the print shop is challenging and stimulating. From an organizational perspective, the failure of Cameron’s first employer to redesign the job into a more satisfying one led to increased turnover. Redesigning jobs therefore has important practical implications—reduced turnover and increased job satisfaction among them.¹⁰

Furthermore, societies and organizations are looking to job design as one way to improve inclusiveness in organizations. Consider Mohsin Khan, a seventy-five-year-old aircraft repair technician—as Khan’s eyesight deteriorated, the company invested in an expensive laser-marker machine with a large screen to help emboss numbers on metal plates to assist Khan in how he does his job.¹¹ Singapore is helping businesses assist and retain older employees through a job redesign grant, available since 2016.¹² This grant has enabled the government and businesses to care for the needs of the aging population and provide a source of life enrichment for older workers. Let us look at other ways that jobs can be redesigned to motivate employees.

8-2 Compare the main ways jobs can be redesigned.

Job Rotation and Job Enrichment

Job Rotation If employees suffer from over-routinization of their work, one alternative is **job rotation**, or the periodic shifting of an employee from one task to another with similar skill requirements at the same organizational level (also called *cross-training*).¹³ One survey of millennial managers and professionals suggests that job rotation is an important aspect of modern work, with roughly 70 percent of respondents rating it as important.¹⁴ Manufacturers also use job

job rotation The periodic shifting of an employee from one task to another.

rotation as needed to respond more flexibly to the volume of incoming orders while also reducing employee boredom and increasing employee motivation.¹⁵ It may also increase safety and reduce repetitive-based work injuries, but that is currently a topic of much study and debate, with mixed findings.¹⁶

New managers are sometimes rotated through jobs, too, to help them get a picture of a whole organization.¹⁷ For these reasons, job rotation can be applied in any setting where cross-training is feasible, from manufacturing floors to hospital wards. At Singapore Airlines, for instance, a ticket agent may temporarily take on the duties of a baggage handler, both to be cross-trained and to get exposure to different aspects of the organization. Extensive job rotation is among the reasons that Singapore Airlines is rated one of the best airlines in the world.¹⁸

Job rotation does have drawbacks. Training costs increase when each rotation necessitates a round of training. Second, moving a worker into a new position reduces overall productivity for that role. Third, job rotation creates disruptions when members of the work group must adjust to new employees. Fourth, supervisors may have to spend more time answering questions and monitoring the work of recently rotated employees.

Job Enrichment The major focus of SDT (see the previous chapter) can be put into action through the process of job enrichment. In **job enrichment**, high-level responsibilities are added to the job to increase a sense of purpose, direction, meaning, and intrinsic motivation.¹⁹ Enriching a job in this way is different from enlarging it (adding more tasks and requirements). It involves adding another layer of responsibility and meaning. Job enrichment has its roots in Herzberg's theories (see the previous chapter) of providing hygiene factors to increase motivation at work.

Early reviews suggest that job enrichment can be effective at reducing turnover, almost twice as effective as giving employees a “realistic preview” of the work before they join the organization.²⁰ In a survey of over twenty thousand British employees, job enrichment practices were related to organizations' financial performance, labor productivity, absenteeism, and output quality through improvements in job satisfaction.²¹ Regardless of these benefits, managers who are high on openness (see the chapter on personality and individual differences) and are in autonomous jobs themselves tend to be more likely to *design* jobs that are enriching.²² Regardless of personality, managers should consider the benefits of job enrichment and work against natural inclinations to micromanage.

Relational Job Design

While redesigning jobs on the basis of job characteristics theory is likely to make work more intrinsically motivating, research is focusing on how to make jobs more *prosocially* motivating to people. In other words, how can managers design work so employees are motivated to promote the well-being of the organization's beneficiaries (customers, clients, patients, and employees)? This view, **relational job design**, shifts the spotlight from the employee to those whose lives are affected by the job that the employee performs.²³ It also motivates individuals toward increased job performance and job satisfaction, especially when coupled with designing and redesigning jobs for autonomy.²⁴ Why do these connections have such positive consequences? Meeting beneficiaries firsthand—or even just seeing pictures of them—allows employees to see that their actions affect a real person and have tangible consequences. It makes customers or clients more memorable and emotionally vivid, which leads employees to consider the effects of their work actions more. Connections allow employees to take the perspective of beneficiaries, which fosters higher levels of commitment.

job enrichment Adding high-level responsibilities to a job to increase intrinsic motivation.

relational job design Constructing jobs so employees see the positive difference they can make in the lives of others directly through their work.



Medical device maker Stryker provides opportunities for its employees to connect with people affected by their work. Shown here are its employees with endurance athlete Daren Wendell (center, in hat), who has an implanted titanium rod in his leg that Stryker produced.

Source: Diane Bondareff/InVision for Stryker/AP Images

One way to make jobs more prosocially motivating is to relate stories from customers who have found the company's products or services to be helpful. For example, the medical device manufacturer Medtronic invites people to describe how its products have improved or even saved their lives and shares these stories with employees during annual meetings, which provides the employees a powerful reminder of the impact of their work.²⁵ For instance, Medtronic found that their services improve the lives of two people *every second*.²⁶ As another example, researchers found that when university fundraisers briefly interacted with the undergraduates who would receive the scholarship money they raised, they persisted 42 percent longer and raised nearly twice as much money as those who did not interact with potential recipients.²⁷ The positive impact was apparent even when fundraisers met with just a single scholarship recipient. Personal contact with beneficiaries may not always be necessary. Once a child's chemotherapy comes to an end at one of the many cancer centers across the United States and they have successfully defeated cancer, it has become tradition for the child to ring a bell, the sound of which is often broadcast throughout many areas of the hospital. The mere act of hearing this bell is inspiring to the staff. Dr. ZoAnn Dryer of the Texas Children's Cancer Center notes, "Every time that bell rings, it's like you know what, somebody else has done it. That's what this is all about."²⁸

Alternative Work Arrangements

Another approach to enhancing motivation is to consider alternative work arrangements such as flextime, job sharing, and telecommuting.²⁹ These are likely to be especially important for a diverse workforce of dual-earner couples, single parents, and employees caring for a sick or aging relatives. For example, flextime and telework can help women continue to advance their careers after childbirth.³⁰ Furthermore, the advent of COVID-19 has renewed an interest in telecommuting as a potentially "permanent" shift in the workforce,

8-3 Explain how specific alternative work arrangements can motivate employees.

an establishment of a “new normal” in the working world.³¹ Before the pandemic, only 15 to 27 percent of workers in the United States worked completely remotely.³² In the midst of the pandemic, 67 percent of employers were taking steps to shift their employees toward remote work.³³

But are alternative work arrangements here to stay? First, some research suggests that around 75 million U.S. employees are *capable of* working from home. This number represents over half (56 percent) of the workforce.³⁴ Second, about two-thirds of people wanted to continue working remotely,³⁵ and a whopping 98 percent of over two thousand remote workers during COVID-19 expressed interest in working this way for the rest of their careers.³⁶ Third, a Gartner survey suggested that 74 percent of the executives surveyed would keep at least a portion of their workforce remote after the pandemic.³⁷ However, the influence of the pandemic did not just heighten interest in telecommuting—flextime and job sharing also received renewed interest, given that it was now easier for people to work whenever, wherever, juggle work and home commitments more flexibly, and use project management and digital versioning software (e.g., GitHub) to quickly pick up work where their coworkers left off.³⁸ Furthermore, COVID-19 continued the heightened interest in the new nature of work in the gig economy (described in the introductory chapter). The often flexible nature of gig work enabled many “frontline” workers to manage home demands while at the same time working when it was convenient for them.³⁹

Flextime

Jim Ware, founder of Focus Consulting Group, notes that “if you’re trying to build a first-rate culture that attracts and retains people, you better make sure you get the rewards piece right and part of that is autonomy.”⁴⁰ Flexibility is a key attractive benefit that organizations can offer employees that helps make their lives easier by giving them a sense of control over when and where they do their work.⁴¹ For example, Polen Capital Management doubled its workforce in three years after instituting a **flextime**, or “flexible work time,” policy.⁴² In countries such as Finland, the majority of full-time workers have a legal right to decide the location and timing for at least half of their working schedule.⁴³ Globally, a number of different flextime arrangements exist, from flexible mealtime, breaks and shifts to “compressed workweeks” (e.g., working longer each day for a shorter number of days each week).⁴⁴

In one arrangement, flextime employees work a specific number of hours per week but may vary their hours of work within limits. As in Exhibit 8-2, each day consists of a common core, usually 6 hours, with a flexibility band surrounding it. The core may be 9:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m., with the “virtual office” opening at 6:00 a.m. and closing at 6:00 p.m. Employees should be working during the common core period, but they may accumulate their other two hours around that. Some flextime programs allow employees to accumulate extra hours and turn them into days off. Some, like the Sterling-Rice Group, even allow employees to “craft” the nature of flexible work (see Myth or Science?): They propose, after being hired, how, when, and where they would like to complete the work and adjust accordingly as they work.⁴⁵ However, most organizations implement the “core business hours” approach to flextime (57 percent of employers) compared with other approaches (29 percent of employers not establishing a common core).⁴⁶

Flextime has become extremely popular, and organizations reap benefits from it as well. For instance, the Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM) reports that organizations can experience enhanced productivity by boosting employee morale, providing employees the ability to work during

flextime Flexible work hours.

Myth or Science?

Job Crafting Is a Practical Way to Reduce Boredom and Burnout

What if you could make your work tasks feel less boring? Well, it turns out that job crafting, a relatively new approach to job design, could transform work that once felt meaningless into something that feels valuable. Job crafting describes how employees can customize their jobs by actively altering their tasks or interacting with others at work to capitalize on their unique skills and abilities. Job crafting has been studied and applied for many years within various organizations, from Fortune 500 companies to small nonprofits. In these companies, it is not uncommon to find employees at all levels and in all types of occupations engaging in job crafting. Employees who do so become more engaged and satisfied with their work, perform better, and develop greater personal resilience.

For job crafting to be successful, employees should draw on their strengths (e.g., specialized knowledge, a particular skill, etc.) to create value for others. For example, suppose you are

an administrative assistant at a primary school. You might view your job primarily as filling out late slips and calling parents when their children are absent. Alternatively, through job crafting, you may begin to see your role more as a liaison. For instance, you could think about using your communication skills to ensure that students are supported both at school and at home.

Job crafting is not always beneficial or even practical. For example, job crafting can create more stress if you take on more work or change your work without understanding your manager's goals for those tasks. The degree to which job crafting can help with boredom and burnout depends on the type of job crafting utilized. A specific type of job crafting, *avoidance demands crafting*, is a strategy by which employees attempt to cope with extreme job demands. For example, you may engage in job crafting by taking on additional work that capitalizes on your skill set, but you avoid pressing demands you need to meet in your "official" job description. Employees using this type

of job crafting may end up not meeting performance expectations, missing deadlines, and letting their supervisors and coworkers down. Furthermore, several studies have found avoidance demands crafting is likely to have other damaging consequences such as work intensification, health problems, and turnover.

There are also certain types of people who may be more likely to experience job crafting benefits. For example, those with a proactive personality are more likely to engage in job crafting behaviors. Some personality traits (e.g., agreeableness, conscientiousness, extroversion, and openness to experience) may predispose some employees to engage in job crafting. Finally, individuals with higher education levels are also more likely to job craft. Education helps to facilitate the acquisition of job knowledge and expertise, which then facilitates job crafting. Thus, while job crafting shows promising benefits for reducing boredom and burnout, employees must use the appropriate type of job crafting and be motivated to engage in job crafting.⁴⁷

hours that better suit their natural energy cycles (e.g., morning larks versus night owls), potentially extending hours of operation, and reducing commuting challenges.⁴⁸ As an example, the Executive Education program at the MIT Sloan School of Management implemented flextime practices and found that employees were actually more productive, especially in the face of commuting challenges (e.g., Boston's harsh winters).⁴⁹ It appears as if flextime has become an important job design element for many employees—50 percent of employees cite flexible arrangements as a very important aspect of their job satisfaction, 34 percent stated that they would remain with their current employer because of flexible arrangements, and 15 percent would seek employment elsewhere in order to obtain more flexibility.⁵⁰

Most of the evidence for flextime stacks up favorably. One review of over 40 studies suggests that flextime is related to positive work outcomes in general, but only weakly—the effects are much stronger when considering reductions in absenteeism and, to a lesser degree, improvements in productivity and schedule satisfaction.⁵¹ Much less promising, the empirical evidence from over 100,000 employees suggests that, although flextime is weakly effective at reducing the

extent to which work interferes with family, it does not affect situations in which family interferes with work.⁵²

However, flextime's effects on work–life balance are more nuanced than they might appear. For example, two studies of German employees suggest that, although flextime leads employees to set stronger work–life boundaries (which in turn makes them happier), these boundaries are not truly “set” unless the employees complete their daily goals at work.⁵³ These studies suggest that if flextime is used too much, it can undermine goal accomplishment. Furthermore, flextime's major drawback is that it is not applicable to every job or every worker. For example, some research suggests both young, healthy employees and older, unhealthy employees benefit the most from flextime.⁵⁴ It also appears that people who have a strong desire to separate their work and family lives are less apt to use flextime.⁵⁵ Those who ask for it are often stigmatized, which may be avoided if the majority of the organization's leaders adopt flexible hours to signal that flextime is acceptable.⁵⁶

Job Sharing

job sharing An arrangement that allows two or more individuals to split a traditional full-time job.

Job sharing allows two or more individuals to split a traditional full-time job.⁵⁷ One employee might perform the job from 8:00 a.m. to noon and the other from 1:00 p.m. to 5:00 p.m., or the two could work full but alternate days. For example, actor-puppeteers Lizzie Wort and Ruth Calkin are now able to tour Britain doing what they love: performing as the Twirlywoos, puppets from a popular UK children's TV program.⁵⁸ This is now possible due to a theatre job share arrangement, which has the “potential to revolutionize” how actors approach touring and “open up possibilities... for performers with children.”⁵⁹

Only 10 percent of U.S. organizations offered job sharing in 2015.⁶⁰ Some of the reasons it is not more widely adopted include the difficulty of finding compatible partners to job-share and the historically negative perceptions of individuals not completely committed to their jobs and employers. However, eliminating job sharing for these reasons might be shortsighted. Job sharing allows an organization to draw on the talents of more than one individual for a given job. It opens the opportunity to acquire skilled workers—for instance, retirees and parents with young children—who might not be available on a full-time basis. From employees' perspectives, job sharing can increase motivation and satisfaction if they can work when they would not normally be able to do so.

An employer's decision to use job sharing is often based on policy and financial reasons. Two part-time employees sharing a job can be less expensive in terms of salary and benefits than one full-timer, but this may not be the case because training, coordination, and administrative costs can still be high. Ideally, employers should consider each employee and job separately, seeking to match the skills, personality, and needs of the employee with the tasks required for the job and considering that individual's motivating factors.

Telecommuting

As noted in the beginning of this section, people rarely had a choice regarding whether to work from home during the COVID-19 pandemic. Although full-time virtual work was only offered by about one in four employers before the pandemic, it was still becoming fairly prevalent, with 69 percent of employers offering it at least occasionally.⁶¹

Regardless, is working from home more effective? Do employees like working from home? For some, it might be close to the ideal job: no rush hour traffic, freedom to dress as you please, and potentially fewer interruptions (depending upon how tumultuous your family life is!). Others

Exhibit 8-2 Possible Flextime Staff Schedules

Schedule 1	
Percent Time:	100% = 40 hours per week
Core Hours:	9:00 A.M.–5:00 P.M., Monday through Friday (1 hour lunch)
Work Start Time:	Between 8:00 A.M. and 9:00 A.M.
Work End Time:	Between 5:00 P.M. and 6:00 P.M.
Schedule 2	
Percent Time:	100% = 40 hours per week
Work Hours:	8:00 A.M.–6:30 P.M., Monday through Thursday (1/2 hour lunch) Friday off
Work Start Time:	8:00 A.M.
Work End Time:	6:30 P.M.
Schedule 3	
Percent Time:	90% = 36 hours per week
Work Hours:	8:30 A.M.–5:00 P.M., Monday through Thursday (1/2 hour lunch) 8:00 A.M.–Noon Friday (no lunch)
Work Start Time:	8:30 A.M. (Monday–Thursday); 8:00 A.M. (Friday)
Work End Time:	5:00 P.M. (Monday–Thursday); Noon (Friday)
Schedule 4	
Percent Time:	80% = 32 hours per week
Work Hours:	8:00 A.M.–6:00 P.M., Monday through Wednesday (1/2 hour lunch) 8:00 A.M.–11:30 A.M. Thursday (no lunch) Friday off
Work Start Time:	Between 8:00 A.M. and 9:00 A.M.
Work End Time:	Between 5:00 P.M. and 6:00 P.M.

might be extremely apprehensive, worrying about the negative effects of virtual work on the work–life boundaries (such as those experienced during COVID-19)⁶² as well as sustaining culture, cohesion, and communication within the workplace.⁶³ For instance, only 5 percent of executives think that employees do not need to be in the office or meet in person at all to maintain a company culture.⁶⁴ Furthermore, many dual-career couples with children had a much harder time with telecommuting during the pandemic, suggesting that telecommuting is only as good as the support received by telecommuters and their boundary management strategies.⁶⁵ **Telecommuting** refers to working at home or anywhere else the employee chooses that is outside the physical workplace.⁶⁶

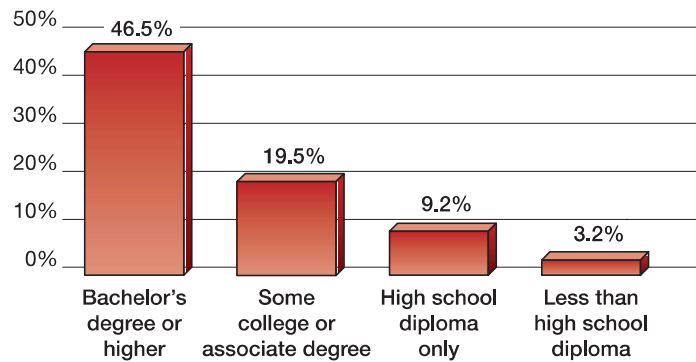
What kinds of jobs lend themselves to telecommuting? McKinsey & Company have recently conducted a widespread study of over two thousand tasks from eight hundred jobs within nine different countries.⁶⁷ McKinsey researchers discovered that, at the industry level, most industries could on average telecommute for at least 29 percent of the time *without productivity loss*. Of course, this figure should be qualified by considering the specific industry. Finance, insurance, management, information technology, and other “knowledge worker” professionals can telecommute for greater periods of time without productivity loss than, say, manufacturing, construction, retail, and food service workers. As shown in the OB Poll, most

telecommuting Working from home or anywhere else the employee chooses that is outside the physical workplace.

OB POLL

Who Works from Home?

Percentage of people working from home



Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics, "Job Flexibilities and Work Schedules—2017–2018: Data From the American Time Use Survey," *Bureau of Labor Statistics* [news release], September 4, 2019, <https://www.bls.gov/news.release/pdf/flex2.pdf>

telecommuters have attained high levels of higher education, demonstrating that many telecommuters are perhaps employed as knowledge workers. At the job-task level, it becomes clear that it is difficult for any job to be fully remote. Even tasks that are the most suitable for telecommuting (e.g., updating knowledge and learning, interacting with computers, and thinking creatively) cannot be done remotely on occasion (e.g., learning how to perform a medical surgery, setting up computer hardware in someone's home, creating a physical prototype for a new product).

Telecommuting has several benefits. It increases performance and job satisfaction; to a lesser degree, it reduces role stress and turnover intentions.⁶⁸ Employees who work virtually more than 2.5 days a week tend to experience the benefits of reductions in work–family conflict more intensely than those who are in the office the majority of their workweek.⁶⁹ Beyond the benefits to organizations and their employees, telecommuting has potential benefits to society. One study estimated that if people in the United States telecommuted half the time, carbon emissions would be reduced by approximately 51 metric tons per year. Environmental savings could come from lower office energy consumption, fewer traffic jams that emit greenhouse gases, and a reduced need for road repairs.⁷⁰

Telecommuting has several downsides too. In today's team-focused workplace, telecommuting may lead to social loafing (i.e., employees shirking responsibility in a team setting), especially when the employees have many family responsibilities but their teammates do not.⁷¹ Your manager working remotely can affect your performance negatively, as they may be less readily available to provide guidance or assistance.⁷² Managers are also challenged to handle the demotivation of office workers who feel they are unfairly denied the freedom of telecommuters.⁷³ The COVID-19 pandemic in particular brought this issue to light, with many "essential workers" being unable to protect their health, reduce job stress, and manage their home obligations (e.g., caring for vulnerable relatives).⁷⁴ From the workers' standpoint, telecommuting can increase feelings of isolation as well as